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MOHAP SURVEY
REACHED 20,000
HOUSEHOLDS,
COMPRISING
40% CITIZENS
AND 60%
RESIDENTS

DUBAI
BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

The Ministry of Health and Prevention (MoHAP) has released the results of the National Health and Nutrition Survey 2024-2025, revealing a sharp 14.8 per cent decline in obesity prevalence across the UAE over the last fifteen years.

The comprehensive study, endorsed by the World Health Organisation (WHO), provides the most detailed mapping of the country's public health landscape to date, tracking shifts in lifestyle, chronic disease risk factors, and maternal care. While the data shows a 2.4 per cent drop in smoking and an 11.7 per cent rise in physical activity levels over the last 7 years, officials noted that significant challenges remain regarding dietary habits and nutrient deficiencies.

People-centred model

Speaking on the findings, Ahmed Ali Al Sayegh, Minister of Health and Prevention, said the survey reflects the UAE's commitment to a people-centred development model. "These findings provide a clear, evidence-based picture of population health trends and reinforce the importance of prevention, early intervention, and long-term planning," he said. "They help direct resources toward priority areas, support families, and improve quality of life."

Despite the downward trend in obesity, the report highlights that 22.4 per cent of adults are

UAE residents smoke less, get more physical activity



Virendra Saklani/Gulf News

■ Participants strike a yoga pose during the Dubai Fitness Challenge 30X30 at Safa Park.

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Ahmed Ali Al Sayegh | Minister of Health and Prevention

still living with the condition. Furthermore, nearly 60 per cent of the adult population does not meet recommended physical activity levels. The clinical data also pointed to high rates

of "silent" health issues, with 54.2 per cent of adults recorded as having high cholesterol and 25.9 per cent suffering from high blood pressure.

The survey reached 20,000

households, comprising 40 per cent UAE citizens and 60 per cent residents, alongside 2,000 individuals in workers' accommodations. Data was collected through face-to-face interviews in multiple languages, including Arabic, English, Hindi, and Urdu, supported by laboratory testing to ensure clinical accuracy.

Nutritional habits

Nutritional habits emerged as a primary area for policy intervention. The data shows that

96.2 per cent of adults exceed the recommended daily sodium intake. Vitamin D deficiency remains a widespread concern, affecting 49.3 per cent of adults and nearly 70 per cent of children.

Maternal and child health

In the realm of maternal and child health, the results were more positive.

The UAE maintains exceptionally high standards of prenatal care, with 99.6 per cent of women attending at least one prenatal visit. However, the disparity in childhood obesity remains a focal point for health authorities, jumping from 2.2 per cent in children under five to 16.1 per cent in the 6-17 age bracket.

Dr Hussain Al Rand, Assistant Undersecretary for the Public Health Sector, stated that the ministry would use the data to refine its integrated public health framework. "The findings enable us to develop innovative health programmes, expand preventive screening, and deliver targeted health messaging, empowering individuals to make healthier daily choices," he said.

Dr Alya Zaid Harbi, Director of the Statistics and Research Centre at MoHAP, emphasised the scientific value of the survey, citing rigorous statistical methods and digital tools used to ensure data reliability. The results are expected to serve as the primary benchmark for the UAE's health strategies over the coming decade, aligning national policy with the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals.

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More firms will now get access to UAE 'citizenship'

New reforms aim to expand UAE's business base to 2m firms by decade's end

DUBAI
BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

More companies established in the UAE will now be formally recognised as Emirati entities after amendments to the Commercial Companies Law expanded and clarified corporate "citizenship" status across the country's business landscape. The update reinforces that all companies set up in the UAE — including those registered in free zones and financial free zones — qualify for Emirati status. Officials said the change is intended to strengthen the identity of UAE-based businesses, improve their access to international markets and support faster growth in company registrations.

Only companies qualify

Speaking at a media briefing, Minister of Economy and Tourism Abdulla Bin Touq Al Marri said the provision ap-

The update reinforces that all companies set up in the UAE — including those registered in free zones and financial free zones — qualify for Emirati status.

plies strictly to the company itself and does not extend to its owners, shareholders or investors. Companies recognised as Emirati entities can more easily leverage the UAE's growing network of Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreements, which lower tariffs, streamline customs procedures and open access to high-growth markets.

"When it comes to being an Emirati company — companies can benefit when it comes to trade, when it comes to benefiting from the agreements that have been signed," Al Marri said. The Ministry of Economy expects the reforms to lift new company registrations by 10 to 15 per cent in the first year. The government is now targeting two million active companies by the end of the decade.

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